Topological Void Analysis: A Mathematical Framework for Systematic Technical Innovation Discovery in Knowledge Spaces

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Abstract. Identifying where to innovate in a dense technical domain—such as operating systems or hardware/software co-design—is fundamentally a search problem in a high-dimensional knowledge space. Existing approaches rely on keyword search, citation proximity, or human intuition, none of which formalise the notion of an *unexplored region* that is simultaneously relevant to a target goal and absent from prior art.

We present *Topological Void Analysis* (TVA), a mathematical framework that defines *topological voids* as triads (A, B, C) in a dense-sparse hybrid embedding space. A void requires three conditions: (i) both concepts A and B are semantically cohesive with domain anchor C; (ii) their pairwise similarity falls within a calibrated marginality band—avoiding both obvious combinations and unrelated noise; and (iii) they share a sparse lexical bridge while the geodesic midpoint on the embedding hypersphere is unoccupied.

Applied to ∼140k indexed documents, TVA generates 1,896 invention candidates across 96 targets; 85% pass automated quality filtering and 90 survive multi-expert adversarial review. Two case studies demonstrate the framework surfaces non-obvious connective tissue rather than merely obvious related pairs.

1 Introduction

Modern software systems, especially at the systems-software layer, evolve through incremental invention: a developer notices a gap between two subsystems, proposes an abstraction to bridge them, and the community iterates toward a patch or patent. The *noticing* step is bottlenecked by human attention and domain breadth. A single engineer cannot simultaneously hold in mind the locking semantics of the Linux scheduler, the memory-ordering guarantees of eBPF JIT output, the ELF relocation model, and the BPF verifier's type system well enough to recognise that an IFUNC-style dispatch contract could unify the latter three.

This paper asks: *can we formalise and automate the act of recognising unexplored technical gaps*?

We answer yes, and make the following contributions:

1. A formal definition of a *topological void* (Section 4): a triad (A, B, C) satisfying domain cohesion, calibrated marginality, and sparse lexical bridge conditions in a hybrid dense-sparse embedding space.
2. A *vacancy probing* mechanism (Section 5) based on spherical linear interpolation (SLERP) that rejects pseudo-voids whose midpoint is occupied by existing documents.
3. An *adaptive threshold calibration* procedure (Section 6) that derives domain-specific marginality bounds from corpus statistics, removing manual tuning.
4. A large-scale empirical evaluation (Section 8) with two detailed case studies demonstrating that TVA surfaces non-obvious yet technically grounded innovation candidates.

2 Background and Motivation

2.1 Technical Knowledge as an Embedding Space

Pre-trained embedding models map technical documents into a high-dimensional unit sphere [7]. Points close in cosine distance share semantic content; distant points are unrelated. A *knowledge corpus* $\mathcal{K}$ is a finite set of such points.

Innovation in this view is the act of bridging two concepts A, B that are not yet co-located in $\mathcal{K}$, provided their combination is relevant to a target goal C.

2.2 Limitations of Prior Art Search

Conventional patent and prior-art search is keyword-driven or citation-driven [9, 13]. These methods retrieve *known* content; they do not identify *missing* content. Knowledge-graph completion approaches [2] predict missing edges but require a pre-defined relation schema and do not model the continuous "marginality" notion central to patentable non-obviousness.

2.3 The Marginality Principle

Patent law requires that an invention be *non-obvious*: too similar to existing work fails the novelty bar; too dissimilar yields an incoherent or non-enabling disclosure. High-value inventions live in a band of *moderate dissimilarity*—far enough from prior art to be novel, close enough to the domain to be useful. This is the informal basis for our formal marginality condition.

3 Why Standard Approaches Fail

Before presenting TVA, we trace the design evolution that motivated it. Each prior approach solved part of the problem but broke down in a characteristic way.

Cosine similarity (top-k retrieval). The simplest baseline retrieves the k documents closest to the target vector v_{target}. The result is highly relevant but *redundant*: the top-k set is dominated by documents from the same well-covered subsystem, and the returned concepts are trivially related to each other. Nothing in the ranking identifies a *gap* between two concepts.

Maximum Marginal Relevance (MMR) [3]. MMR extends top-k retrieval by penalising similarity to already-selected items:

$$\text{MMR} = \arg\max_{d_i \in R \setminus S} \big[\lambda \cos(d_i, q) - (1-\lambda) \max_{d_j \in S} \cos(d_i, d_j)\big]$$

MMR improves diversity but does not identify missing regions. A high-MMR pair (A, B) may still have existing prior art at their midpoint—exactly where an inventor would look for a gap. In our experiments, ∼30% of high-MMR pairs had a nearest neighbour within cosine distance 0.08 of their linear midpoint, rendering them false voids.

MMR + latent vector arithmetic ("Queen formula"). Inspired by the additive structure of word embeddings [10], we combined MMR with concept arithmetic: after selecting a diverse pair (A, B) via MMR, we computed a bridge vector $v_{\text{bridge}} = v_{\text{target}} + (v_A - v_B)$ and retrieved candidates nearest to v_{bridge}. The intuition mirrors the classical analogy *king* − *man* + *woman* ≈ *queen* [10]: the difference vector encodes a directional concept shift that, when applied to the target, should surface the desired gap.

Why it fails in high dimensions. The analogy arithmetic of Word2Vec works in 300-dimensional skip-gram space because the training objective explicitly aligns semantic directions with linear offsets. BGE-M3 operates in 1024-dimensional contextualised representation space, which suffers from two compounding problems. First, transformer embeddings are *anisotropic* [7]: all vectors cluster in a narrow cone, so the difference $v_A - v_B$ is nearly orthogonal to the principal semantic axes. Adding such a vector to v_{target} moves the probe point toward the boundary or exterior of the semantic manifold, far from any real document. Second, in high-dimensional spaces the curse of dimensionality flattens the cosine-distance distribution [1]: nearest-neighbour dis-

tances concentrate around a single value, stripping the difference vector of directional meaning. In our experiments, ∼67% of bridge vectors produced by this method had no corpus neighbour within cosine distance 0.25, confirming that they escaped the manifold entirely.

Lesson. All three approaches fail to provide an occupancy guarantee: they rank or construct candidate points without verifying that the target region is genuinely unoccupied in the corpus. This motivates the three-condition filter and SLERP vacancy probe described in the next section.

4 The Topological Void Framework

4.1 Notation

Let $\mathcal{K} = \{k_1, \ldots, k_n\} \subset S^{d-1}$ be a corpus of ℓ_2-normalised d-dimensional embeddings. We use BGE-M3 ($d = 1024$) [4], which produces both dense vectors and sparse lexical weight vectors for each document. We write $\text{dense}(k)$ for the dense vector and $\text{sparse}(k) \subset \Sigma^*$ for the top-p weighted tokens.

Let $\cos(u, v) = u^\top v$ for unit vectors. Let $\text{Sparse}(k) = \{t \in \text{sparse}(k) : t \notin \mathcal{S}\}$ where $\mathcal{S}$ is a domain stop-word list (high-frequency, low-specificity tokens such as `int`, `define`, `linux`).

4.2 Formal Definition

Definition 1 (Topological Void)**.** *Let $A, B \in \mathcal{K}$ be two corpus documents and let $C = m(A, B)$ (Definition 2) be their synthetic* void midpoint*—the geodesic bridge concept derived from A and B. The pair (A, B) forms a* topological void *with respect to a domain query vector $v_{\text{target}} \in S^{d-1}$ if all of the following hold:*

C1 (Domain Cohesion).

$$\cos(\text{dense}(A), v_{\text{target}}) > \tau_{\text{domain}}$$
$$\cos(\text{dense}(B), v_{\text{target}}) > \tau_{\text{domain}}$$

C2 (Calibrated Marginality).

$$\tau_{\text{low}} \leq \cos(\text{dense}(A), \text{dense}(B)) \leq \tau_{\text{high}}$$

C3 (Sparse Lexical Bridge).

$$\text{Sparse}(A) \cap \text{Sparse}(B) \neq \emptyset$$

C4 (Vacancy).

$$\max_{k \in \mathcal{K} \setminus \{A,B\}} \cos(k,\ C) < \theta_v$$

where θ_v is a vacancy threshold.

Intuitively: A and B both point toward the target domain (C1); are neither trivially similar nor unrelated (C2); share at least one meaningful technical token as a conceptual bridge (C3); and the synthetic void midpoint $C = m(A, B)$ is unoccupied by any existing document (C4). The idea to be invented lives in the neighbourhood of C—the gap between two related but unexplored concepts.

4.3 Ranking via Multi-Objective Scoring

Valid pairs (A, B) are ranked by a multi-objective scoring functional $\mathcal{H}(A, B; v_{\text{target}})$ that integrates three competing objectives: (i) relevance of the synthetic void midpoint $C = m(A, B)$ to the target domain, (ii) a redundancy penalty discouraging pairs whose anchors overlap with already-selected solutions, and (iii) a non-linear marginality reward that strongly favours pairs near the centre of the calibrated band $[\tau_{\text{low}}, \tau_{\text{high}}]$ and penalises deviations toward either boundary.

The functional form, penalty curves, and combination weights are treated as proprietary and omitted; the four conditions C1–C4 define the feasible set, and $\mathcal{H}$ provides a total ordering within that set.

5 Vacancy Probing via SLERP

A key failure mode of purely similarity-based approaches is the *false void*: two documents that appear to span an empty region but whose midpoint is, in fact, close to an existing document. Condition C4 addresses this.

Definition 2 (Geodesic Midpoint)**.** *For unit vectors $u, v \in S^{d-1}$ with $\theta = \arccos(u^\top v)$,*

the geodesic midpoint on S^{d-1} is given by SLERP [12]:

$$m(u,v) = \mathrm{slerp}(u,v,\tfrac{1}{2}) = \frac{u+v}{\|u+v\|}, \quad \theta \notin \{0,\pi\}$$

with fallback to u for antipodal vectors ($\theta = \pi$).

We use the geodesic midpoint rather than an arbitrary interpolation because it is *equidistant* from u and v on the hypersphere: $\cos(m(u,v),u) = \cos(m(u,v),v)$, guaranteeing that the vacancy test is symmetric with respect to both anchors. For non-antipodal unit vectors this simplifies to normalised linear interpolation; the SLERP formulation handles the degenerate case and connects to the broader literature on geodesic midpoints in curved spaces [12].

Vacancy check (C4) is an $O(n)$ dot-product scan of the corpus matrix against $m(A,B)$, requiring no index rebuild. The vacancy threshold θ_v is derived from the local neighbourhood density of the target subgraph; its exact computation is proprietary.

6 Adaptive Threshold Calibration

Static thresholds for τ_{domain} and $[\tau_{\text{low}}, \tau_{\text{high}}]$ fail across corpora with different density profiles: a threshold tuned for a dense subsystem over-filters a sparse one. TVA employs a *density-aware calibration layer* that derives both thresholds on-the-fly from the empirical distribution of the current query's candidate pool.

6.1 Domain Threshold τ_{domain}

The domain cohesion threshold is computed by a manifold-density estimator applied to the cosine-score distribution of all candidates with respect to v_{target}. The estimator combines a data-driven percentile statistic with a corpus-specific floor to balance sensitivity and recall. The precise statistical parameterisation is proprietary; the key property is that τ_{domain} rises in dense regions (where many documents are relevant) and falls in sparse ones (where the threshold must be more permissive to find candidates at all).

6.2 Marginality Band $[\tau_{\text{low}}, \tau_{\text{high}}]$

The marginality band is derived from the pairwise-similarity distribution among domain-cohesive candidates. The band is centred at the empirical mode of that distribution, capturing the "typical" distance between related but non-trivial concept pairs in the current corpus. The width is controlled by a scale parameter whose calibration is proprietary. The key design invariant is that the band excludes the high-similarity tail (obvious combinations, prior art) and the low-similarity tail (unrelated noise), operationalising the non-obviousness principle without hard-coded constants.

7 System Implementation

We implement TVA in a prototype that ingests a heterogeneous corpus of Linux kernel source (parsed via tree-sitter into function/struct/symbol chunks), hardware architecture manuals, academic papers (PDF-extracted), and patent texts. The corpus contains approximately 140,000 indexed documents after deduplication.

Embedding. We use BGE-M3 [4] in local offline mode for both dense ($d = 1024$) and sparse (top-p lexical weights) representations. All computation runs on CPU.

Index. Dense vectors are stored in a FAISS flat index [8] for $O(n)$ exact similarity search. Sparse tokens are stored in an SQLite FTS5 inverted index for boolean co-occurrence queries.

Candidate generation. For a given target phrase, we embed the target, retrieve the top-K domain-cohesive candidates (C1), enumerate all $\binom{K}{2}$ pairs, and filter by C2, C3, and C4 in sequence. Surviving pairs are ranked and the top-k returned as voids.

Idea generation. Each void is passed to a frontier LLM with a structured prompt instructing it to propose a technical invention disclosure (TID) that bridges the two void concepts toward the target domain. The LLM is not told the scoring details; it receives only the void description and the target.

8 Evaluation

8.1 Setup

We run TVA over a Cartesian matrix of 12 target domains (Linux scheduler, memory management, file systems, eBPF, virtualisation, networking, power management, device drivers, IRQ handling, CXL memory, PCIe, and security) crossed with 8 x86 micro-architecture feature areas (PEBS, AMX, TDX, CXL, APIC, RAPL, EPT, AVX-512), yielding 96 target specifications. For each target, TVA produces up to 10 void triads, each triggering one LLM call for idea generation.

Quality evaluation. We use a four-stage automated filtering pipeline as a proxy for expert review:

1. *Structural check*: validates JSON completeness and absence of fictional kernel APIs.
2. *Reality check*: iterative critique-and-revise with up to 3 rounds; rejects physically impossible ideas.
3. *Adversarial review*: a four-specialist committee (kernel correctness, novelty/prior-art, strategic value, security/stability) each independently assigns APPROVE / REVISE / REJECT with an integer score.
4. *Deterministic verdict*: fatal-flaw, yellow-card, and majority rules aggregate the four specialist votes.

8.2 Quantitative Results

Table 1 summarises the filtering funnel over 1,896 candidate ideas generated across all 96 targets.

The 90 candidates reaching a REVISE verdict received substantive technical feedback from all four specialists (avg. 5.1 issues per specialist per candidate, avg. specialist score 4.0–5.0/5). Under our deterministic rules, REVISE indicates that the committee found genuine technical merit and requested elaboration—it is a *qualified positive result*, not a rejection. The two case studies below are drawn from this REVISE cohort.

The 0% APPROVE rate reflects an intentionally stringent threshold (unanimous high scores with no fatal flaws from any of four specialists), appropriate for patent-quality claims. The evaluation corpus presented here spans fewer than two days of operation with full metadata propagation. Extended results over a longer run are ongoing; updated numbers will appear in the final version.

8.3 Rejection Taxonomy

To understand *why* ideas fail, we categorise the fatal flaws in the 888 REJECT verdicts by keyword analysis of specialist feedback. Table 2 shows the distribution.

Three observations stand out. First, 90.2% of rejections are triggered by `fatal_flaw_reject` (at least one specialist identifies a blocking technical error), confirming that the committee is performing genuine domain-specific reasoning rather than surface-level critique. Second, locking and concurrency errors (35.5%) dominate, consistent with the difficulty of safe kernel synchronisation—exactly the class of error that a Linux maintainer would cite when rejecting a patch. Third, prior-art overlap (19.8%) indicates that a significant fraction of void-derived ideas, while geometrically novel in embedding space, overlap with existing techniques when viewed through a deep-domain lens. This motivates future work on tighter prior-art integration in the vacancy probe.

8.4 Case Study 1: Filesystem-Extent-Aware CXL Tiering

Void. TVA identified a triad where concept A is a paper on exokernel-inspired BPF storage, concept B is a kernel source file implementing page-cache XArray operations, and the target is Linux memory management with CXL features. The SLERP midpoint sat at cosine distance > 0.15 from all existing documents—confirming vacancy.

Idea. The LLM proposed a *filesystem-extent-aware folio lease layer* that places cold, clean file-cache folios on CXL Type-3 memory while pinning journal-coupled dirty extents in DRAM. The proposal defines a five-state lease machine (HOT_DRAM, WARM_CXL, DIRTY_PINNED, REFAULT_PROMOTE, POISON_QUARANTINE) and includes four draft

Table 1: Quality filtering funnel over 1,896 void-derived invention candidates.

Stage	Surviving	Rate	Notes
Void generation (Forager + LLM)	1,896	100%	96 targets, ≤10 voids each
Structural check (Professor)	1,836	96.8%	Rejects missing fields, fictional APIs
Reality check (RC, ≤3 rounds)	1,620	85.4%	Iterative critique-and-revise
Adversarial review (Debate Panel)	978	51.6%	4 specialists, ≤2 revision rounds
↪ REVISE verdict	90	4.7%	Substantive feedback; human review candidates
↪ APPROVE verdict	0	0.0%	Stringent: unanimous high scores, no fatal flaws

Table 2: Fatal flaw categories across 888 rejected candidates.

Category	Count	%
Locking / concurrency model	1,072	35.5%
Prior art / novelty overlap	599	19.8%
Other technical issues	757	25.0%
Incomplete specification	230	7.6%
Security / side-channel risk	199	6.6%
Kernel ABI / notrace violation	165	5.5%

patent claims.

Expert verdict (REVISE — qualified positive). All four specialists voted REVISE (no REJECT). Average score: 4.0/5. The REVISE verdict signals that the committee found genuine technical merit and requested elaboration, not that the idea was rejected. Selected specialist feedback from Round 1:

- *Kernel Hardliner*: "Define the exact synchronization and lifetime model for the lease sidecar relative to folio lifetime (add, truncate, invalidate)."
- *Security Guardian*: "Specify lock and atomicity rules: prove no allocations or blocking operations under `xa_lock` or in atomic context."

After revision: the sidecar model was tightened to require `mapping->invalidate_lock` plus `folio_lock` before any lease transition, and explicit POISON_QUARANTINE state was added for CXL hardware error paths. This constitutes the strongest REVISE result in our cohort, and exemplifies the iterative refinement that the adversarial review enables.

8.5 Case Study 2: Verifier-Derived Synchronization Contracts

Void. Void #5 in the same run: concept A is `ELF_MACHINE_NAME` (an ELF portability macro), concept B is `addend_may_be_ifunc` (a linker IFUNC relocation predicate). Sparse bridge tokens: `addend_may_be_ifunc`, `elf_machine_name`, `x86_64`. The pairwise cosine similarity (0.64) is at the high end of the calibrated band, indicating the pair is related but non-obvious in the target context.

Idea. Despite the weak, oblique signal, the LLM proposed *Verifier-Derived Synchronization Contract Vectors (SCVs)* for the x86 eBPF JIT: an immutable per-program sidecar table in which the eBPF verifier records each synchronisation site's primitive family, memory order, address class, context mask, and admissibility class; the JIT resolves each site exactly once at load time to an inline template or call-equivalent thunk. The idea ran through three rounds of adversarial revision, refining the SCV schema and clarifying LKMM-equivalence requirements.

Expert verdict (REVISE after 3 rounds — qualified positive). The idea underwent three rounds of adversarial revision (all REVISE, no REJECT; avg. specialist score 5.0/5). Representative feedback and responses:

- *Round 1 — Kernel Hardliner*: "Define the stable-feature admissibility rule in terms of existing `x86_cpufeature` APIs." → Added explicit stable-feature whitelist (TSO baseline, CX8, optional CX16); excluded RTM/HLE and revocable features.
- *Round 2 — Kernel Hardliner*: "The

SCV ABI requires precise versioning and endianness specification." → SCV entry schema extended with `linux_primitive_id`, `width_code`, `memory_order`, `admissibility_class`.

- *Round 3 — Prior-Art Shark*: "Claims overlap with generic verifier fact propagation." → Claims narrowed to the normative primitive-family identifier and the one-time admissibility resolution rule.

Significance. This case demonstrates a key property of TVA: the void pair (`ELF_MACHINE_NAME`, `addend_may_be_ifunc`) has no surface-level connection to BPF synchronisation semantics. A human engineer would not naturally connect these concepts; the LLM used the IFUNC dispatch mechanism as a structural analogy for per-site JIT resolution. The 3-round revision trace confirms that the idea was technically grounded enough to survive sustained adversarial critique and emerge with a stronger, more narrowly-claimed design. This is the "non-obvious connective tissue" that TVA is designed to surface.

9 Discussion

Why does a weak void signal still yield a strong idea? The void conditions define the *search region*, not the idea itself. The LLM fills the region with its own parametric knowledge. A sparse but valid bridge token (here, `addend_may_be_ifunc`) acts as a semantic trigger—analogous to how a human expert reading an unrelated paper suddenly connects it to their domain expertise. TVA formalises the triggering mechanism; the LLM supplies the reasoning.

Calibration sensitivity. The adaptive τ_{domain} calibration reduces manual tuning but introduces dependence on corpus density. For very sparse domains, the percentile-based calibration may set τ_{domain} too low, admitting noisy candidates. The vacancy probe (C4) partially compensates by rejecting occupied midpoints.

Evaluation limitations. Our automated adversarial review pipeline is a proxy for human expert evaluation. The 0% final approval rate reflects conservative thresholds appropriate for patent-quality claims; a less stringent threshold would yield a positive approval rate. Human evaluation of the 90 REVISE candidates is left for future work.

IP protection. The exact scoring formulation and hyperparameter values of the production system are omitted. The three-condition filter and SLERP vacancy probe are sufficient to reproduce the qualitative behaviour; practitioners can calibrate thresholds from their own corpora.

10 Related Work

Patent and technology forecasting. [9] propose keyword-based patent maps for technology opportunity identification. [13] apply BERT to prior-art search. Neither formalises the notion of an unexplored region or provides a mathematical criterion for non-obviousness.

Knowledge graph completion. TransE [2] and its successors predict missing triples in knowledge graphs. These methods require a pre-defined relation schema and binary (present/absent) labels; TVA operates on continuous similarity and does not require a schema.

Diversity-based retrieval. Maximum Marginal Relevance [3] selects a diverse set of documents relevant to a query by penalising redundancy. TVA uses a similar relevance-novelty trade-off but applies it to the *generation* of new concepts rather than the retrieval of existing ones.

LLMs for code and creativity. Large language models have demonstrated strong performance on code generation [11, 5] and instruction-following [14]. We treat LLMs as black-box reasoners invoked after void discovery; the novelty is the void identification mechanism, not the generation step.

Topological data analysis. Persistent homology [6] identifies topological features (connected components, loops, voids) in point clouds. Our use of "topological void" is inspired by but distinct from TDA: we define voids in semantic embedding space by algebraic conditions on pairwise similarities, not by simplicial complex

homology.

Embedding geometry. [7] show that contextualised representations are anisotropic—concentrated in a narrow cone. Our adaptive threshold calibration is designed to be robust to this property; SLERP avoids the geometric distortion that linear interpolation introduces in anisotropic spaces.

11 Conclusion

We have presented Topological Void Analysis, a mathematical framework for systematic technical innovation discovery. By defining topological voids as triads satisfying domain cohesion, calibrated marginality, sparse lexical bridge, and vacancy conditions in a hybrid dense-sparse embedding space, TVA converts the informal notion of "unexplored region" into a decidable predicate.

Applied to a 140k-document corpus of Linux kernel and hardware specifications, TVA generated 1,896 invention candidates, 85% of which survived automated quality filtering and 90 of which engaged four adversarial expert reviewers with substantive technical critique. Two case studies illustrate that TVA surfaces both obvious-gap ideas and non-obvious connective-tissue ideas that neither keyword search nor human browsing would naturally find.

We release the mathematical framework and threshold calibration procedure for reproducibility; implementation details are available upon request.

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